David A. Vivian
Visiting Assistant Professor of French Language and Culture
Soka University of America | dvivian@soka.edu | website

Education

PhD in Comparative Literature and French, University of California, Santa Barbara, 2023
Dissertation: *From Messiahs to Mangroves: Towards a Caribbean Eco-Epistemology*
Committee: Eric Prieto, Chair (French/Comparative Literature); Renan Larue (French/Comparative Literature); Roberto Strongman (Black Studies/Comparative Literature)

MA in Comparative Literature and French, University of California, Santa Barbara, 2018
Thesis: "Flânerie and Modernity in Urban French Literature, from Balzac to Breton."
Committee: Catherine Nesci, Chair (French/Comparative Literature); Dominique Jullien (French/Comparative Literature); Maurizia Boscagli (English/Comparative Literature)

BA in Literature (Intensive), University of California, Santa Cruz, 2015
Cum laude; University Honors; Honors in Literature; NCAA soccer; Phi Beta Kappa.

Publications

Academic Writing

"A Conversation with Stephanie Saulter: Adaptation and Resilience in the Multicultural Sci-Fi City." *Urban Discourses of Crisis, Resilience, and Resistance: Cities Under Stress*, eds. Lanigan, Lappälä, and Prieto. Palgrave Macmillan, 2025 [link]

"The Complexity of Community: Ecology, Science Fiction, and the Future of Literature — A Conversation with Tobias Buckell." *Journal of West Indian Literature* 31.1 (2022) [link]

"Exploring Postcolonial Prejudice and Ecology through Science Fiction — An Interview with Stephanie Saulter." *sx salon* 40 (2022) [link]

"Non-Anthropocentric Ecologies in Jacques Stéphen Alexis's *Romancero aux étoiles* and Yanick Lahens's *Bain de lune*." *Journal of Haitian Studies* 28.1 (2022) [link]

"Eco-Epistemology and Eschatology: Examining the Savior Complex in Jacques Roumain's *Gouverneurs de la rosée* and Patrick Chamoiseau's *Les neuf consciences du Malfini*." *French Forum* 45.2 (2020) [link]

In Progress

Decolonial Ecologies in Francophone Caribbean Literature: From Messiahs to Mangroves. Under contract with Liverpool University Press. (Manuscript under peer review)

"Reimagining Urban Ecology through Caribbean Science Fiction: Reading the Green Cities of Tobias Buckell and Stephanie Saulter." *Journal of Modern Literature*. (Forthcoming, 2026)

"*Que peut littérature quand elle ne peut?* par Patrick Chamoiseau" (review [in French]) *French Review* 99.4. (Forthcoming, 2026).

"Ecology Against Empire: The Césaires' Decolonial Ecology Avant La Lettre." (Invited article for special issue "Ecologies of Empire," *Bulletin of Francophone Postcolonial Studies*)

Editor, *Toxicity in Contemporary Global Fiction: Perspectives from the Environmental Humanities*. Under contract with Routledge. (Routledge Environmental Humanities series; manuscript in progress)

"Urban Poverty and the Promise of Paradise: Space, Place, and the Ethics of Terrorism in Mahi Binebine's *Les Étoiles de Sidi Moumen*." (Article in peer review at *Francosphères*)

Editor (with Lauren D. Ravalico), *Toxic Imaginaries: Environmental Toxicity and Narrative Form in French and Francophone Culture*. (Proposal submitted to Liverpool UP)

Public Writing

"The colonial legacy lurking beneath economic unrest in the French Caribbean." *The Conversation*, 1 November 2024 [link]

"What Is Comparative Literature and Why Study It?" *Culture Frontier*, 12 May 2023 [link]

Fellowships, Honors, and Awards

President's Research Assistantship Program, Soka University, Spring, Summer, and Fall 2025

Mellon Foundation Grant, "Africana Studies and the Humanities at Skidmore: Transnational Explorations in Social Justice," Skidmore College, Spring 2024

Research Travel Grant (Martinique), Comparative Literature Program, UC Santa Barbara, Fall 2022

Dissertation Write-In Fellowship, Graduate Student Resource Center, UCSB, Fall 2022

Academic Senate Teaching Assistant Award, nominated, UCSB, Winter 2021

Graduate Certificate of Excellence in Translation, Comparative Literature Program, UCSB, Spring 2019

Jean Belin Research Fellowship, Department of French and Italian, UCSB, Summer 2017

Pierre and Geneviève Delattre Recruitment Fellowship, Dept. of French and Italian, UCSB, Fall 2016

Phi Beta Kappa, UC Santa Cruz, 2015

Invited Talks

Soka University, Fall 2024

"Urban Poverty and the Promise of Paradise: Mahi Binebine's *Horses of God*." EMP 335: *Cities and Environment in the Global South* (Prof. Deike Peters), October 3, 2024

Amherst College, Spring 2024

Public lecture, sponsored by the Department of French: "Creole Creativity as Plantation Resistance: A Postcolonial-Ecofeminist Perspective," March 13, 2024

University of California, Santa Barbara, 2017-19

C LIT 191/FR 153D: *Fantasy and the Fantastic* (Prof. Dominique Jullien; Tegan Raleigh; Prof. Rebecca Powers), Fall 2019; Summer 2018; Spring 2018

C LIT 100: *Intro to Comparative Literature* (Alexandra Magearu), Winter 2017

Teaching Experience

Literature and Culture Courses (Sole Instructor)

Soka University (Aliso Viejo, CA), Visiting Assistant Professor of French and Francophone Studies, 2024-

FRN 413: *Relation and Resistance in Caribbean Literature*, Fall 2026

FRN 410: *The Art of Translation: Theory and Practice*, Fall 2025

FRN 402: *Introduction to Francophone Literature*, Spring 2025

FRN 490: *Decolonial Ecologies of the Caribbean*, Fall 2024

Skidmore College (Saratoga Springs, NY), Visiting Assistant Professor of French, 2023-24

WLF 363: *Informal Cities in the Francophone World*, Spring 2024

Mellon-sponsored faculty seminar: *Black Ecologies: Environmental (In)justice and Radical Resistance*, Spring 2024

Université de Paris-VIII (Saint-Denis), Visiting Lecturer, Spring 2022

English B1: *The Anthropocene: Rethinking the Human-Environment Relation*

Culture and Communication B1: *Environmental Discourse: Media and Climate Change*

Culture and Communication B2: *Media, Sports, Politics: The Chaotic New Rules of Contemporary Sports*

University of California, Santa Barbara,[1] Teaching Associate, 2018-20

FR 154F: *Paris, "la ville aux cent mille romans" (1830-1930)*, Summer 2020

FR 147D: *Literary Translation: Theory and Practice*, Winter 2020

C LIT 30B: *Love Bound and Unbound (1600-1800)*, Summer 2018

Literature and Culture Courses (Teaching Assistant)

University of California, Santa Barbara, Teaching Assistant, 2018-20

C LIT 30C: *The Modern World in Six Novels*, Spring 2019

Language Courses

Soka University, Visiting Assistant Professor of French and Francophone Studies, 2024-

FRN 101: Beginning French I, Fall 2025

FRN 102: Beginning French II, Spring 2025; Spring 2026

FRN 201: Intermediate French I, Fall 2026

FRN 310: Advanced Conversation, Fall 2024

FRN 311: Advanced Grammar and Composition, Spring 2025; Spring 2026

Skidmore College, Visiting Assistant Professor of French, 2023-24

WLF 101: Elementary French I, Fall 2023; Spring 2024

WLF 102: Elementary French II, Fall 2023; Spring 2024

WLF 220: Languages across the Curriculum, Fall 2023

El Encanto Hotel (Santa Barbara, CA), Freelance instructor, 2022-23

English as a Second Language (ESL) I, Fall 2022

English as a Second Language (ESL) II, Spring/Summer 2023

University of California, Santa Barbara, Teaching Assistant, 2016-20

I taught all levels of the beginning and intermediate French series (FR 1-6), including repeated instances of FR 1-4.

[1] *n.b.* UC Santa Barbara runs on the quarter system (Fall/Winter/Spring/Summer).

Readerships

University of California, Santa Barbara, 2018-22

C LIT 171/FR 154G: *The Informal City in Film and Literature* (Prof. Eric Prieto), Fall 2021; Fall 2022

C LIT 186FL: *Animal Ethics in Literature* (Prof. Renan Larue), Spring 2020

C LIT 191/FR 153D: *Fantasy and the Fantastic* (Prof. Dominique Jullien; Prof. Rebecca Powers), Fall 2019; Spring 2018

C LIT 100: *Migrant Tales and Tales Untold: Introduction to Comparative and World Literature* (Prof. Catherine Nesci), Winter 2019

Research Assistantships

University of California, Santa Barbara, 2018-21

Prof. Eric Prieto (French/Comparative Literature), Summer 2021

Prof. Dominique Jullien (French/Comparative Literature), Fall 2019

Prof. Catherine Nesci (French/Comparative Literature), Summer 2018

Undergraduate Mentorship

President's Research Assistantship Program, Soka University, 2024-present

I have now mentored five undergraduate research assistants across two major projects. Three students have supported my ongoing book project by analyzing archival materials from the Archives territoriales de Martinique, compiling notes, and assisting with formatting and bibliographic integration. A fourth student began assisting me with my translation of Patrick Chamoiseau's *Les neuf consciences du Malfini*, helping in the editing process and with necessary research, and a fifth student is continuing as the fourth student studies abroad. These collaborations have provided students with hands-on experience in archival work, literary scholarship, and translation practice.

Digital and Pedagogical Methodologies

Teaching Methods

- "Tableau virtuel" digital class workspace
- Adapting course design through continuous student feedback (Google Forms)
- Digital textual analysis through Gallica (Bibliothèque nationale de France)
- Collaborative student projects using tools such as ArcGIS StoryMaps

Platforms and Tools

- VHL Central and other online textbook platforms
- Brightspace, Canvas, and other LMS
- Google Workspace for Education
- Microsoft Suite
- Generative AI
- Kahoot
- ArcGIS StoryMaps

Conference Papers

"Translation, Relation, Ecology: Towards a Composting Theory of Translation in the Age of AI and Climate Crisis"
"Translation Studies." The Pacific and Ancient Modern Languages Association (PAMLA), San Francisco, November 20-23, 2025

"Toxicity and Coloniality"
"Toxic Exposure: Chemicals in Contemporary Global Fiction." The American Comparative Literature Association (ACLA) Annual Conference, May 29-June 1, 2025

"Creole Creativity as Plantation Resistance: A Postcolonial-Ecofeminist Reading of Patrick Chamoiseau's *Le Vent du Nord dans les fougères glacées*"
"Beyond the Anthropocene: New Perspectives in Postcolonial Environmental Humanities." The ACLA Annual Conference, Montréal, March 14-17, 2024

"The Landscape in/of Postcolonial Ecocriticism: A Caribbean Case Study"
UCSB's Graduate Center for Literary Research (GCLR) Annual Conference, "Landscape and Garden in Art, Literature, and Film," University of California, Santa Barbara, May 27, 2023

"Where Sci-Fi Meets Cli-Fi: Reimagining the City in Caribbean Science Fiction"
Association for Literary Urban Studies (ALUS) 3rd International Conference, "Cities Under Stress: Urban Discourses of Crisis, Resilience, Resistance, and Renewal," UCSB, February 17-19, 2022

"Emergent Eco-epistemology: Caribbean Ecopoetics and Climate Change"
UCLA's Annual Southland Conference, "Emergences," August 10-11, 2021

"'First we were enslaved. Then we were poisoned': Environmental (In)justice in the Postcolonial French Caribbean"
UCLA's Environmental Humanities Graduate Student Conference, "Environmental Justice: Flashpoints, Forms, Futures," July 9, 2021

"Decolonial Ecology in the French Caribbean: Reading the Chlordecone Crisis through Édouard Glissant and Maryse Condé"
The University of Pittsburgh French & Italian Department Graduate Student Conference, "Academia in Action: Breaching the Ivory Tower," May 15, 2021

"Chaos in the Anthropocene: Subjectivity, Time, and the Role of Fiction in Ben Lerner's *10:04*"
The Graduate Center for Literary Research Annual Conference, "Climate Fictions," UCSB, November 21, 2020

"The Haunting Past: Trauma, Time, and (Post)Memory in Patrick Modiano's *Dora Bruder*"
The Centre for Comparative Literature's 29th Annual Conference, University of Toronto, March 29-30, 2019

"The Spatio-Temporal Poetics of Memory: Patrick Modiano's *Dora Bruder*"
The Charles F. Fraker Graduate Student Conference, "Complex Spaces: Navigating Text and Territory," University of Michigan-Ann Arbor, February 15-16, 2019

"Toxic Masculinity and the Gender Politics of Meat"
"Veganism and Gender" panel, organized by Vegans of UCSB and Professor Renan Larue, UCSB, November 27, 2018

"Creole Space, Creole Text: Urbanization and Literature in Patrick Chamoiseau's *Texaco*"
UCLA's Department of French & Francophone Studies Graduate Student Conference, "Que sais-je ? Rethinking Learning and Knowledge," UCLA, October 12–13, 2017

Service

Academic

Faculty Participant, Experience Soka Orientation (for the Language & Culture Program), Soka University, April 3, 2026

Round Table Organizer and Participant, "Urban Informality Across the Disciplines: A Conversation with Eric Prieto." Soka University, March 10, 2026

Seminar Co-Organizer, "Toxic Exposure: Chemicals in Contemporary Global Fiction." The American Comparative Literature Association (ACLA) Annual Conference (held virtually), May 29-June 1, 2025

Chapter Moderator, Pi Delta Phi (Rho Lambda chapter), Soka University, 2025-

Supervisor, French Tutors, Soka University, 2025-

Founder/Coordinator, Francophone Film Series, Soka University, 2024-

Faculty Member, Faculty Sustainability Working Group, Soka University, 2024-
- **Chair**, Spring 2025

Volunteer English Tutor, Association for Senegalese Students, Paris-VIII, Spring 2022

Co-founder/Participant, Memory Studies Research Group, UC Santa Barbara, 2018-21
Volunteer Advisor, Major Discovery Event, Education Opportunity Program (EOP), UCSB, Winter 2019

Panel Organizer, "Veganism and Gender." Panel sponsored by UCSB's Vegan Studies group, Fall 2018

Volunteer Advisor, W.E.B. Du Bois Event, EOP, UCSB, Spring 2017

Associate Editor, Comparative Literature Newsletter, UCSB, 2016-17

Coordinator/Facilitator, French Conversation Club, UCSB, 2016-20

Community

Co-founder, Vegan Studies Group, UCSB, 2017-20

Beach Cleanup Volunteer, Surfrider Foundation, Isla Vista, 2016-22

Professional Associations

American Comparative Literature Association (ACLA)

Association for Literary Urban Studies (ALUS)

Association for the Study of Literature and the Environment (ASLE)

Modern Language Association (MLA)

Pacific Ancient and Modern Language Association (PAMLA)

Pi Delta Phi (ΠΔΦ)
Honorary Member; Moderator, Rho Lambda, Chapter #417

Phi Beta Kappa (ΦBK)

Additional Relevant Work Experience

Freelance translator, 2022 – present

- Current translation project: *Les neuf consciences du Malfini* by Patrick Chamoiseau (submitted for consideration for the Humanities in Translation prize at Northwestern University Press).
- French translation assistance for *Exhortation to the Monks by Hyperechios*, trans. Tim Vivian (Cairo: The American University in Cairo Press, 2024).
- Co-translation (with Jules Dormoy) of subtitles for the film *Le Naméssime* (dir. Xavier Belony Mussel).

Freelance writer and editor, 2021-23
Clients included academics as well as companies such as Palo Alto Networks and SurveyMonkey.

Independent tutor, 2015-23
Tutoring students of all ages and skill levels, primarily in French, English (including ESL), and writing.